The original BRICS idea emerged partly from the Moscow-Beijing strategic partnership and as a follow-on to the continuing trilateral group, Russia-India-China (RICs). This precursor was the brainchild of Yevgeny Primakov, Boris Yeltsin's last prime minister and a former diplomat, who sought to contain the U.S. global influence by finding opportunities for Russia to be an influential pole as the dominant Eurasian power in a multipolar world.[105] Although Russia was already a prominent player on the global stage, having inherited the Soviet Union's permanent seat on the UNSC, it did not emerge from the Soviet detritus as a global economic or financial power outside of energy markets. Russia possessed neither full autonomy over its monetary policy and economic destiny nor what many Russian elites considered their rightful influence in the former Soviet space. Putin's emergence as Yeltsin's successor coincided with Russia's economic and geopolitical resurgence after the economic crises of the 1990s. Putin oversaw key market reforms in his first term, (2000–2004) as oil prices skyrocketed and Russia's economy boomed, dramatically improving living standards in the first decade of the twenty-first century.[106] By the second half of that decade, Russia had become a global financial power, with a net positive international investment position and a sizable war chest of foreign currency reserves.[107]

Together with other rising (or resurgent) economic powers not well represented in the elite of incumbent rule-makers associated with the G7, Moscow felt entitled "to take its rightful place in the global governance system."[108] Russian officials had an easy sell for their BRICs idea because the other potential members of this informal club also recognized that their economic growth "does not automatically guarantee [them] a corresponding increase . . . in global decision-making."[109] In an article published on the eve of the 2012 elections–and Putin's return for a third presidential term–Putin wrote that Russia would give "high priority to interaction with BRICS partners," a "unique structure" that "vividly symbolizes the transition from unipolarity to a more equitable world order."[110]

At the BRICS Summit that year, then–President Dmitri Medvedev emphasized that "our organisation can become one of the key elements in the global governance system."[111] In 2009, at the inaugural BRICS summit, Medvedev declared, "We need to make sure our countries . . . take part in defining the new rules."[112] Putin approved Russia's BRICS strategic